

My vort for אלול was inspired by a number of people, including Rabbi Oelbaum, is as follows: We know that the month of אלול is distinctive in that every day we say וְיִשְׁעֵי אֲוִרֵי ה' לְדָוֶד. In that קאפיטל there's the pasuk אַחַת שְׁאֵלָתִי מֵאֵת ה' - there is only one thing that I'm asking for. Then we go home and we wash and we have a nice fresh roll and a little scrambled egg or whatever, and then we bentch. In bentching we say:

לָחֵן וּלְחֶסֶד וּלְרַחֲמִים וּלְרוּחַ הַצֵּלָה וְהַצְלָחָה בְּרַכָּה וְיִשׁוּעָה, נְחֵמָה, פְּרִנָּסָה וְכִלְכֵּלָה, וְרַחֲמִים, וְחַיִּים - I need, הקדוש ברוך הוא וְשָׁלוֹם, וְכָל טוֹב. And הקדוש ברוך הוא, in case I left anything out, וְיִסְתַּרְנֵנוּ אֵל טוֹב לְעוֹלָם אֵל יִסְתַּרְנֵנוּ. If I forgot something, please throw in all the other good stuff that you can do.

So hang on. Ten seconds ago, you said, I'm only asking you one thing, אַחַת שְׁאֵלָתִי. And now you're asking an entire list. It's an endless list. וְיִסְתַּרְנֵנוּ אֵל טוֹב לְעוֹלָם אֵל יִסְתַּרְנֵנוּ - it's an infinite list.

The תירוץ is there is one thing in bentching that we do not want. לא לִידֵי מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם - everything that I need should come directly from you, not from מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם. חס ושלום, we should never have to come on to מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם. Let me ask you a question. A kid comes home from school and he says, 'Ma, what's for supper?' So she gives him supper. Is that called מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? An older kid asks, 'Daddy, I'm getting בר מצוה, can I have a Borsalino?' 'Okay, you can have a Borsalino.' Is that מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? An even older kid comes along and says, 'Dad, can I borrow the car keys?' Is that מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? And even better, 'Can I have a car?' Is that מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? No, that's not מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם. Why? Because that's called משפחה, that's called your family. When you're getting something from your father, mother, and family, that's not מִתְנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם.

What are we asking Hashem? אַחַת שְׁאֵלָתִי מֵאֵת ה' ... שְׂבָתִי בְּבֵית ה' כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּי - Hashem, I want to be part of your משפחה. I want to live in your house. I want to be close to you, as close as a father and a mother. When you ask שְׂבָתִי בְּבֵית ה' כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּי, that I want to live in your house, then you can ask for everything. That's why when we bentch, we can ask for everything. May we be זוכה that וְהַחֲמִימָה טוֹבָה, and to have a wonderful

